

Taylor believed in many things that he dubbed scientific but that our modern eyes perceive as mere prejudice. He believed in the inherent superiority in both intelligence and character of aristocratic men over the working classes and the superiority of men over women; he also thought that lower-status people should be supervised strictly by their betters. These beliefs are part and parcel of Taylor's time, and it is tempting to forgive him for having been blind to them.

Yet when our time is viewed through the lens of future practice, what prejudices will be revealed? In what forces do we place undue faith? What might we risk losing sight of with this initial success of our movement?

It is with these questions that I wish to close. As gratifying as it is for me to see the Lean Startup movement gain fame and recognition, it is far more important that we be right in our prescriptions. What is known so far is just the tip of the iceberg. What is needed is a massive project to discover how to unlock the vast stores of potential that are hidden in plain sight in our modern workforce. If we stopped wasting people's time, what would they do with it? We have no real concept of what is possible.

Starting in the late 1880s, Taylor began a program of experimentation to discover the optimal way to cut steel. In the course of that research, which lasted more than twenty-five years, he and his colleagues performed more than twenty thousand individual experiments. What is remarkable about this project is that it had no academic backing, no government R&D budget. Its entire cost was paid by industry out of the immediate profits generated from the higher productivity the experiments enabled. This was only one experimental program to uncover the hidden productivity in just one kind of work. Other scientific management disciples spent years investigating bricklaying, farming, and even shoveling. They were obsessed with learning the truth and were not satisfied with the folk wisdom of craftspersons or the parables of experts.

Can any of us imagine a modern knowledge-work manager with the same level of interest in the methods his or her employees use?